Free painting – intuition

When we paint freely, with no goal and no effort at a pretty picture, blue often appears at a moment when we need **calm**, space, or when we want to say something and do not know how. Sometimes we know exactly why, sometimes not at all. Both are fine.

What may hide behind a blue stroke

The same blue line on paper can mean something completely different every time, depending on what is happening in us just then. Sometimes it is **calm**, sometimes **longing**, sometimes simply the taste of the colour. That is why there is no point in reading a picture like a test with a single right answer.

Longing for calm and quiet.

Wide horizontal strokes, like a water surface. The colour is spilled out and nothing pushes it onward.

A need to express yourself.

The stroke heads outward, to the edge of the paper, or repeats around something. As if it wanted to say something.

Sadness and longing.

A darker, muted blue, sometimes running or smudged. Low on the paper, like rain.

Loneliness and distance.

A large empty cold area with one small dot in it. Blue keeps people apart.

Perspective and space.

A light, sky blue, at the top of the paper. A feeling that it is possible to breathe.

Depth and mystery.

A dark, rich, midnight blue. Something hides under the surface and does not want to come up yet.

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Blue in a picture. Can it express what is happening inside?

Yes, it can, but it does not have to. When painting you sometimes reach for a colour before you can name what you feel. Blue can then give form to **calm**, a longing for space, but also to **longing** or a feeling that something has stuck in your throat.

It can just as well be simply a pretty colour that you happened to have at hand that day. It gains meaning only in connection with your experience. A colour itself does not know what happened to you. You do, or you will find out in time.

Art therapy also works with the idea that a picture can express something for which words are hard to find. What matters, though, is not one patch of colour but the whole picture and how it came about. Your situation, memories, the movement of your hand and your feelings while painting.

A predominance of blue alone is not enough for a verdict on whether it is **calm** or coldness. Maybe you wanted to rest. Maybe you simply enjoyed that blue so much that no other had a chance that day.

When you want to say something and do not know how

Sometimes you have the words on the tip of your tongue, but they do not yet have a first sentence. **Try** first to paint how you feel the sentence. Wide stripes at the top, a circle that opens, or a single line heading for the edge. It does not have to become a pretty picture. It is enough for the sentence to appear on paper before it appears in your mouth.

Then look at the picture and **try** to write the first word that comes to you. **You do not have to** show it to anyone. A word on paper is often the first step to a sentence that you will one day say aloud.

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When blue takes over the space

First let it come. Maybe you reach for blue and have no idea why. Let it appear on the canvas without any duty to explain whether it is **calm**, **longing** or a memory of the sea. **You can** paint standing, on the floor, with your hand, a brush or a piece of cloth. What matters is what happens to you as you spread the colour, layer it or let it take up more room.

Three things worth noticing

- **QUANTITY**

A drop at the edge, or a whole sea?

A small blue trace can be the centre of the whole picture for you. A large area can feel calm and wide, or start to be too cold. A large blue area is not proof of calm and a small trace does not mean you cannot rest. When you want to, notice. Do I want to dive into it, or do I need more warmth around it?

- **SATURATION**

Icy purity, or a veiled dusk?

A pure cyan is fresh, with white it turns sky blue, with umber smoky. If relief floods you after adding white, it is precisely that change that is interesting. Perhaps a lighter look suits you today. You do not have to draw a conclusion about your whole personality from it.

- **THICKNESS**

What does it feel like under your hands?

Thick paint you can push and leave a trace in. Thin paint spreads, runs and can surprise you with a direction you did not plan. One time the substance and resistance please you, another time the chance to let go of control and watch what happens. It is not a test of courage. Even a careful thin stroke can be exactly your language today.

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What to take from the picture

It does not matter how the blue stroke looks. More important is what you feel while making it, what situation you are in and what is happening in your life. Two almost identical pictures can have a completely different story. One was made after a long day full of people, the other after a week when you needed no one. That is why you will not find a dictionary here, but questions. Life does not fit into one colour table anyway.

What the picture may tell you later

Perhaps after a while you will notice that you kept coming back to blue in a period when you were missing **calm**, space or words for what you feel. Perhaps you will link it with a completely different experience. In self-reflective work inspired by art therapy a picture can serve as a trace of your own experience and a chance to look back. Meaning arises in connection with your memories, not from reading the shade alone.

Answers often do not come right away

Sometimes you look at a picture and it tells you nothing at all. And in a week, a month or a year it suddenly comes: “Aha, this is what I was carrying in myself then.” That is fine. The picture is not running away. **You do not have to** squeeze an answer out of it with a still wet brush.

Neither is wrong and neither is right. **Calm**, **longing**, **perspective** and silence all belong to you and blue can carry everything.

If very strong or **painful** feelings appear while you paint, do not stay with them alone. Talk about them with someone close or with an art therapist or therapist. This page does not replace professional care.

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